few months of the administration, when escalation seemed to be the chosen US approach in East Asia—an approach he had publicly criticized. But he feared that continuing American suspicion of the communist countries would prevent a settlement.[9] And, as he told Dulles that May in Delhi, the likely alternative was war on a "much wider and more intensive scale"—as the secretary of state had himself indicated.[10]

While Nehru thought the US was too suspicious, the administration thought he was not suspicious enough of China and the Soviet Union. This shaped its attitude on aid for India. Dulles told Congress that the Indian prime minister was "quite naïve" and not "fully grounded as to facts" on certain matters.[11] It was worth supporting India to ensure it did not lose the China-India race, but only on a limited basis—and not to the extent of $200 million, as the Truman administration had recommended for FY1954.[12] Still, Cold War logic meant a $110 million request, of which $90 million was authorized amid grumbling in Congress that India was not on the US side and Nehru had not been "playing fair with [the US] all along."[13]

Nehru's attitude also contributed to the Eisenhower administration's doubts about India's involvement as an intermediary between China and the US. Washington used India as a channel to China—Dulles, for example, sought to warn Beijing through Delhi that, if necessary, the US would "extend the area of conflict."[14] But, more often than not, the administration tried to eliminate or limit Indian involvement as a mediator—during the Korean crisis and after. Most of these efforts failed, however, and American attempts to exclude India only exacerbated the strain between the two countries.

In the waning stages of the Korean War, as settlement proposals flew back and forth, the US unsuccessfully tried to prevent India from being chosen as the neutral state in charge of postwar prisoner of war (POW) repatriation. U. Alexis Johnson, in the State Department Bureau of Far Eastern Affairs (FEA), outlined the reason: India seemed to be "'more neutral' toward the Chinese Communists than toward the UN."[15] For General Mark Clark, commander of the UN forces, India's neutrality was not "as well defined" as that of some other candidates.[16] Dulles thought India would be acceptable, if necessary, as long as the operating guidelines were set out firmly.[17] On Capitol Hill, Senator Knowland expressed opposition since, on Korea, India had "perhaps 80 percent of the time voted